It wouldn’t be an exaggeration to say that, as a standalone and sustained political event, the Bharat Jodo Yatra is unparalleled in scope and scale. Vinoba Bhave’s fabled walk across India in the Bhoodan movement in the 1950s and 1960s may have taken more time, but it doesn’t match up to the BJY in the number of people involved. The same goes for Gandhi ji’s iconic Salt March. It should be noted that we are not comparing impact, but simply the magnitude of the exercise. No wonder, then, that party General Secretary Jairam Ramesh called it the ‘longest political walk by the second-oldest political party in the world’.

Even after a year, what stands out for most yatris is the sheer energy and excitement each day of the march. Sometimes it was the seemingly unflagging marching band churning out a popular number after another to the accompaniment of cheering crowds. And sometimes it was the Seva Dal ‘jhanda tukdi’ in their sparkling white, singing old Congress-party classics. There were people dressed up in tribal outfits, such as at the border of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. There were also children dressed up as Mahatma Gandhi and Subhas Chandra Bose in Burhanpur, Madhya Pradesh. It is about the stomach-churning excitement generated when lakhs of people come together at the end-of-the-day rally, such as in Bellary, Karnataka.

The BJY was an exercise in practical politics, a celebration with song and dance enveloping the senses. But it was also a remarkable operation, remarkably executed.

The Man in the Middle

If much of the credit for the execution goes to the various state party organizations and the Congress party leadership, some of it should also be given to the national, state and local party leaders who made it happen.

But at the centre of it all was one man. Rahul Gandhi was simultaneously the public face of the Yatra and the lightning rod for much of the criticism that came its way. Behind the scenes, he was an